



UNDER GADKARI'S LEADERSHIP, THE BJP WOULD HOPE TO REGAIN ITS LOST GLORY

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WEAKNESSES

- Is new to Delhi
- Seen as a provincial leader
- Is known to be impatient
- Lacks charismatic appeal
- Electoral inexperience

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OPPORTUNITIES

- Low expectations of BJP
- Party in dire straits
- Is a dark horse
- No major polls till 2012
- No clear competitor

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THREATS

- May fall to internal strife
- Trouble from allies
- Afflicted by aggressive candour
- Penchant for rabble rousing

palate. His success or failure would depend on his ability to stay unaffected by the buzz created by the spin masters. His appointment in one group briefing was described as that of a chief executive officer in a family-owned concern as an episode of shareholder activism. Whispers of him being a provincial leader, not having won elections and lack of national exposure are already doing the rounds.

His appointment does find endorsement though. Former Goa chief minister Parrikar, who was also considered for the top job, feels Gadkari "is the right choice for the moment because he is pro-active and an efficient administrator". Outgoing president Rajnath Singh brushes aside the whispers and

describes Gadkari as "a reputed leader who is imaginative and able".

The baptism has been fiery for Gadkari. The BJP continued its run of poor electoral performance in his first three days in office. On December 21 in Karnataka, the BJP lost 15 of 25 council seats because the Opposition got together and in Nagpur, his backyard, the party lost three MLC seats because the opposition votes got fragmented. Worse on December 23, the party lost the Assembly polls in Jharkhand, adding another feather in the Congress's cap. The truth is that the party, riven by dissent and aggrandisement at every level, is an organisational mess. And the best illustration of it is the pitched battle in Rajasthan be-

tween the RSS-BJP and the non-RSS-BJP. At an ideological level, the party is bankrupt. If it rose from just four Members of Parliament to 120 in 1991, it was because it had an idea that could be transformed into a movement. It succeeded because of the Congress's idiocy but, more importantly, in Vajpayee and Advani, the party had both the brand and the bandwagon.

Gadkari will have to recreate the brand and reorganise the bandwagon. He owes his prodigal rise to what Munde ascribes as "development orientation and ability to think on the feet". A largely unknown factoid within the parivar is his friendship with Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi. And in Modi, he has a strong ally.